



BEDOUINS

ARAB WANDERERS OF THE MIDDLE EAST

settled and nomadic. Settled Arabs found fertile land and cultivated it, while nomadic herdsmen—Bedouins—traveled between oases, extracting

The Bedouin way

The detailed knowledge the Bedouins have of the deserts meant that in the past they controlled trade routes, acting as guides and charging taxes to those who wanted to cross the desert. Although many Arab countries romanticize the Bedouin lifestyle, they are frequently less enthusiastic about actual Bedouin groups who make use of the desert's precious resources despite not owning the land. Some have tried to make the Bedouin abandon their nomadic ways and settle in one place.

HOSPITALITY

In the vast, inhospitable deserts, meeting a stranger is an unusual event and a welcome surprise. *Diyafa*—or honoring guests—is part of the Bedouin code of behavior, so guests will always be welcomed and plied generously with sweet tea, strong coffee, and the best food available.



AT THE BACK OF THE TENT

These women are spinning wool and milling grain. Bedouin women tend the flocks, do the housework and cooking, and are also responsible for pitching and dismantling the tents. They are protected by a strict code of honor and many live less restricted lives than their non-Bedouin counterparts. Bedouin tents are divided into two sections. The front is reserved for men, and the back for women.



DESERT CLOTHING

Women wear long dresses that are often dyed or beautifully embroidered. All women cover their heads and some also wear a veil. The coins on this woman's veil show how wealthy her family is. The traditional dress for a man is a roomy robe worn with a checked or plain headscarf. The scarf is secured with a doubled black cord called the *agal*.

